

SWAHILI PALACE

In around 1300, the Sultan of Kilwa built a palace to prove his power as the leader of one of the most important trading centers on the Swahili coast of eastern Africa. These were part of a huge network that stretched across the Indian Ocean. Ships would sail in on the yearly monsoon winds to trade and only leave when the winds changed. They brought influences from abroad which blended with the rich local culture.



Husuni Kubwa palace was built on the north coast of Kilwa Kisiwani island.

Ruins of Kilwa's Great Mosque, one of the first mosques built on Africa's east coast.



The Swahili coast

Along the coast of east Africa, the Swahili region stretched from what is now Somalia in the north to Sofala in modern Mozambique in the south.

Kilwa Kisiwani island

Islands along the coastline offered shelter from the open sea and became important trading centers. Kilwa Kisiwani had a thriving town and a large mosque, not far from the sultan's palace.

The inscription on these coins is in Arabic.

The text is in rhyme. Rhyming couplets start on one side and finish on the other.

Beads found at Husuni Kubwa, made from glass, clay, and minerals.



Pretty and useful

Beads were used for trade, as well as to make long necklaces for Swahili women. Many imported beads have been found in Kilwa, as well as local beads made from aragonite, a pearl-like mineral from the shell of the giant clam.

Kilwa coins

Coins are useful for trade, so it is not surprising that many were minted in Kilwa. The coins were made from copper and feature poems about the sultan who reigned when they were made.



Archaeologists use a large sieve to look for artifacts hidden in the sand.



Digging up details

Many clues about how people lived in Kilwa are hidden in the ground. Archaeologists sift through the sand and soil, hunting for pieces of pottery, beads, and coins.

